It was understandable, for so far only a few individuals and small groups had travelled abroad, that too on short assignments. Here was an opportunity to live and work for at least a year, may be more than three years in Vernon, just 75 km away from Paris.

Adding to the attraction, those selected for long duration—we would send back people and bring in new members to suit the requirement to meet the planned man hours—could bring their families along. The only ban was on pregnant or ailing wives, as the medical cover for the scientists and families was limited, even non-existent in a sense. This was to prove a big challenge for me in the immediate years to come.

As soon as applications for the Project Vikas team were invited, there was a rush. Some 1,500 people applied within a week. We needed, at a time, a little more than fifty people and, on the whole, some hundred people. Dhawan constituted a selection committee with him as the chairman, all group directors as members, besides me as the member secretary. It comprised V R Gowarikar (solid propellant director), A E Muthunayagam (propulsions director), S C Gupta (control, guidance and instrumentation), Amba Rao (structures), A P J Abdul Kalam (SLV-3 project director), Y Janardhana Rao (aerodynamics), M K Mukherjee (materials and quality care), Brahm Prakash (VSSC director), T N Seshan (administration director) and U R Rao (satellite division head).

The first task of the selection committee was to shortlist 500 from the 1,500-odd applicants, and then handpick fifty-five for the first team.

A caveat: since the team was to report to me through the long assignment abroad, I wanted scientists and engineers who were not just brilliant, but also those who shared with me the fire in the belly. And yes, they all had to do what I wanted them to—and that was nothing personal, since all I wanted was to master this technology, though you could accuse me of doing it my way. In short, I did not want men, even if qualified, with the wrong attitude. While I went about ensuring that the team was to my liking, I expected allegations of favouritism. As long as my conscience was clear, even with the little tricks I played to handpick one man over another